



CITY OF BOSTON BRAND GUIDELINES

Version 1.0.0 ([See version control history](#))

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CITY OF BOSTON BRAND GUIDELINES

BACKGROUND

The Boston brand was officially launched in August 2016, after being developed in partnership with the City of Boston and [IDEO](#). [Article 1](#), [article 2](#), [article 3](#) about the launch.

The launch of the brand was a meaningful step in making the City's digital services accessible for all residents and users. The new site was designed with accessibility at the forefront. More than 20,000 web pages and one million words were rewritten to make the site easier to understand and navigate. We also made dramatic changes to improve ADA compliance, and Boston.gov was also optimized for any device and screen size.

In order to build a website that reflected the needs of a large and diverse community, the City relied heavily on input from a wide variety of residents. A pilot version of the website, launched in January, 2016, allowed the City to conduct rigorous user testing, including in-person conversations, focus groups, and surveys with residents.

The purpose of our Brand is to increase and promote accessibility and create trust with our residents through consistency. Our brand is a tool for the City and departments to make it easier and more convenient for them to communicate with residents and continue to build that trust.

Our brand guidelines also help us be accessible to all our residents. Our balanced mix of colors and typefaces helps us deliver that official but human tone.

The three required visual elements of our brand that promote accessibility and consistency are:

LOGOS

All graphic design materials should have one of the [City of Boston logos](#). [Departmental logos](#) should also be added depending on the use case.

COLORS

The site's primary colors drive the personality of the site and direct users to important notifications and moments of functionality. The vivid colors help with contrast **accessibility**.

FONTS

Both Lora and Montserrat were chosen because of their high readability, flexibility, and accessibility. They have been optimized to work for both print and web.

You can find the online version of the brand guidelines on boston.gov/brand. The online brand guidelines are the paired down guidelines for the brand. The next two sections outline the more detailed guidelines. As you can see, these are divided between the **must-have** brand visual elements that are **required**, and additional brand visual elements that departments can leverage as it is useful.

ACCESSIBILITY

As a government agency we are legally required to make sure all our content and graphics are ADA accessible. We do this in a few different ways.

For our more detailed accessibility guide go to:

COLOR CONTRAST

Everytime you make a graphic that has color on top of color (for example white text on top of a blue background) you need to check it with the [contrast color tool](#) to make sure that it passes color contrast requirements. We aim for it to be AAA passable, but AA is acceptable.

LANGUAGE

When we keep text simple and at a lower reading level it makes our content more accessible.

You can see all our writing tips at boston.gov/writing but another tool we like to use is the [hemingway editor](#). The editor is a free online tool where you can insert any text and it will tell you how difficult your text is to read. We try to aim for an 8 grade reading level or below.

OTHER

- Make **links**, **emails**, and **phone** numbers bold.
- Don't use underlines. They are hard to read and confuse people into thinking it's a link they can click.
- Don't overuse bold. If everything is bold, nothing is bold.
- Avoid making headlines that use the B logo instead of actual text. For example "B smart", "B happy", "B good". They can't be translated and eliminate a majority of Boston residents that might not be able to read english.
- Don't center text. Left align it for better readability.

TRANSLATIONS

As part of our goal to make the City of Boston accessible for everyone, written content should be available to residents in the top languages spoken in the City.

For more details, see the [content translation protocol](#) from the Language and Communications Access Department.

Departments should work with the Language and Communications Access Department for their translation needs.

IMPLEMENTATION NOTE

Designing graphics with translations can be very tricky to do and depending on what tech you're using, not every language is in our branded fonts. Use your best judgment when choosing another similar font if our branded ones aren't working.

Canva is usually pretty good at getting all the translated text correct. Adobe not so much, especially not with Arabic. In the english version of Adobe it won't let you change the direction of the text in the correct way that makes Arabic appear correct. To do Arabic translations you need to download the Arabic version of the program. [This guide](#) takes you through the steps.

When in doubt, you can always input the translations into canva and then screenshot it and import it into Adobe.

REQUIRED VISUAL ELEMENTS

The three core visual elements required for the Boston Brand are:

1. Logos
2. Typography
3. Color palette

#1. LOGOS AND SEAL

1.1 City of Boston logos

CITY of BOSTON

PRIMARY LOGO

This is our main logo. It should be used on **all** marketing materials from the City.



SECONDARY LOGO

Mostly used for the website or in instances when the long logo can't be used. We use the B as a way to strike a friendly tone.

1.2 City and Mayor Seal

There are two versions of the seal, the digital and the old seal. The digital version is the newer and improved version of the old seal, and we prefer this one is used. The old seal isn't the best resolution as it's an old copy of an old copy, so when interacting with residents we prefer to use the primary City of Boston logo. The only time we need to use the old version is when we are asking for money (as told by legal).



Mayor Michelle Wu

MAYOR LOGO

This is the main logo for the Mayor. You don't have to add this logo on materials unless you are asked to by the Mayor's office or the press team. This logo **should not** be used instead of the City of



Mayor Michelle Wu

Boston logo.



City of Boston
Mayor Michelle Wu

COMBINED COB + MAYOR LOGO

This logo should rarely be used. A lot of people try to use this instead of the separate cob and mayor logo. Don't let them.



City of Boston
Mayor Michelle Wu



DIGITAL CITY SEAL

This is the digital version of the old city seal. It has been simplified and vectorized.



OLD CITY SEAL

The old city seal. There are many other versions floating around but this is the official one we use.

1.3 Department logos

[Departmental logos](#) are visual representations of the specific department/cabinet. With simple and solid shapes, they are meant to be recognized by residents at a glance. They are filled with Charles Blue and underlined with Freedom Trail Red.

- Department icons should always be used with its name next to it. The logos are not recognizable by themselves.
- Should always be used in combination with the primary cob logo. Start off with the city logo to the left, followed by any other logos you have.

- **Only departments and cabinets get logos**, and only if they have a department page on boston.gov.

Non-branded logos

Sometimes departments make their own logos or have outside agencies make logos for them that are not on brand. This isn't allowed.

A lot of programs and initiatives also think they need their own logos, we try to avoid that for a couple of reasons:

- To keep our brand consistent and not oversaturate our residents with logos.
- If every project and program got its own logo there would be over 10000 logos floating around which hurts our brand image.

#2. TYPOGRAPHY

There are two typefaces that make up Boston.gov's typographic language. They have been chosen for their contrast, as well as their boldness. Lora and Montserrat.

2.1 MONTSERRAT

With its design inspired by urban streets and the posters found there, Montserrat is bold, strong, and official. Yet, it has a few small quirks that give it a friendliness and warmth that you don't usually find in such sturdy sans-serifs. Use it for navigation, buttons, and primary headers. **Always** use it in **UPPERCASE bold**

2.2 Lora

Lora is a well-balanced contemporary serif typeface with roots in calligraphy. It is polite, poetic, and warm as a typeface and is well suited for body text. Technically, Lora is optimized for screen appearance, but works equally well in print. Use it small for body text, or large and italic for quotes or other special secondary text. Pair with Montserrat whenever possible to reflect our bold, yet human voice.

#3. COLORS

3.1 Primary colors

We have three main colors in the brand, **optimistic blue**, **charles river blue**, and **freedom trail red**. The primary colors are the bursts that direct the eye to important

things on your graphics. Use the blues and white strongly and purposefully, and use the red sparingly.

[Here are the hex codes for the primary and supporting colors.](#)

Why use red sparingly?

Red can be an alarming color that demands direct attention. If a lot of things on your graphic are red, It can cause distress in your viewer and make your content hard to read.

3.2 Additional color palette

We know that sometimes we need a bit more color options than just the three main ones. That's why we developed the [additional color palette](#). The additional color palette includes a wide variety of other colors that can be used for design.

However, when using one of these colors, our recommendation is that you include at least one of the primary colors in the design as well, to provide visual consistency to residents when they are looking at designs from multiple departments in their day-to-day lives.

Use your best judgment when using the additional colors.

OPTIONAL VISUAL ELEMENTS

ICONS

We have two types of icons, [experiential](#) and [small circular](#) icons.

You can use the experiential icons for specific actions a constituent may want to take (like paying a parking ticket). Use them for transactions that need to jump off the page quickly so constituents can get in, and get it done. These icons are built using 3-pixel-width strokes and usually (but not always) have hard edges. Avoid too many unnecessary rounded corners.

The small circle icons use a similar style to the experiential icons. They are surrounded by a 3 pixel circle and filled with our dark blue color. You will notice these being used on the homepage and on “Place” pages, but they could be used anywhere.

PEOPLE AND ANIMAL ILLUSTRATIONS

The [people's illustrations](#) are visual representations of people you can find in Boston.

Note: They don't have facial features as the illustrations are usually pretty small and facial expressions can not always be seen at a small scale. This also helps us because people can fill in their own representation of the characters, which makes it feel more personal.

The [animal illustrations](#) are basically the same as the people illustration just in animal form. The animals do get facial expressions but very simple ones.

PATTERNS

Using [patterns](#) is a super easy way to spruce up some graphics.

BRAND GUIDELINES CHANGE CONTROL

VERSION NUMBER	REVISED BY	EFFECTIVE DATE	DESCRIPTION OF CHANGES
1.0.0	Julia Gutierrez Santiago Garces Jessicah Pierre	4/19/2023	First detailed version of City of Boston Brand Guidelines